FAKE EVIDENCE CHECKLIST

When "Perfect" Evidence Deserves a Second Look

Should you be questioning the pivotal evidence?

These days, the short answer is yes. But not all evidence warrants a deep dive.

The questions need to start when you begin to see this pattern:

[A Single Piece of Perfect Evidence and No Original Explained by A Complicated Story.]

FIVE SIGNS THE EVIDENCE MAY BE FAKE

- [ ] **INCONSISTENT FONTS**

  Look closely: does the font shift mid-document—from Arial to Times New Roman, or system default to something stylized? Headers, timestamps, and metadata fields shouldn't vary.

- [ ] **MIXED DATE FORMATS**

  "1 March 2025" in one line and "Mar 1, 25" in another. If the date format changes within the same document or thread, authenticity is in question.

- [ ] **DIFFERENT SIZES OR LAYOUTS**

  Are the screenshots from a single text thread shown in different sizes or UI styles? That may point to screenshots from different devices—or intentional manipulation.

- [ ] **SECONDARY SOURCE ORIGIN**

  Is the evidence coming from someone copied on the message, rather than the sender or direct recipient? That's not just a red flag—it's a gap in the chain of custody.

- [ ] **CONTRADICTORY CONTEXT**

  Does surrounding evidence undercut the supposed "smoking gun"? For example, a signed contract followed by an email requesting the signature. Look for what doesn't fit.

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When the story is complicated, and the evidence is perfect,

IT'S TIME TO ASK MORE QUESTIONS.

What To Do When the Flags Go Up

- ***Compare Across Sources***

  Cross-reference with backup systems, alternate devices, or third-party logs. Discrepancies tell stories.

- ***Request the Native Format***

  Screenshots and PDFs are static. Native files preserve metadata, context, and creation history.

- ***Get a Forensic Opinion***

  When it matters most, bring in experts to analyze provenance, tampering, and integrity.

Complicated Stories Deserve Verification

Some real-world explanations sound messy:

"The Russians hacked my email." | "My daughter wiped the hard drive."

"Last night my ex-boss started DM'ing me on FB and admitted everything I alleged and a little bit more."

"I found an old iPhone that was in a drawer, and though broken, it held the perfect sexual harassment text message from my boss."

"Someone else must have hacked me because the only other person who had the password was my jealous lover who set up my security."

"I was having problems with my computer so I took a picture to show IT. But the problem resolved. Coincidentally the picture validates the email in question by showing it in my outbox."

These can all be true. But truth should come with evidence—not just a narrative.

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